had not read anything during the series – which was my way of keeping myself insulated from all the hype – and I was unaware of what they had written about me. I didn't have a problem with getting flak if I had not performed. The media needed to do its job, after all. But I was not looking forward to reading the papers just because I had scored some runs – I did not need validation from the media. Criticism and praise are two sides of the same coin and, having played international cricket for fifteen years, I had learnt to take these things in my stride.

We backed up the first-innings batting performance with a very good bowling effort and dismissed Australia for 474, with Anil taking a remarkable 8–141. We were ahead by 231 and now we needed quick runs to give our bowlers time to close out the match. Yet again we batted well and Rahul and I were in the middle of a good partnership when Sourav sent two or three messages out to check when we should declare. Rahul was the vice captain of the team and I said to him that it was his decision as much as Sourav's. I was ready to go off whenever they wanted. Rahul was keen to bat on for a little longer and we finally declared just after he was hit on the head by a Brett Lee bouncer when he was on 91 and I was on 60 not out. In hindsight I must say we delayed the declaration too long. The ball was turning and bouncing, and we should have given Anil and the bowlers a few more overs on the fourth evening than the four they eventually bowled.

Set 443 to win, Australia were under pressure throughout their second innings. Anil bowled a marathon spell of forty-two overs, picking up four more wickets on the fifth day. In his final innings in Test cricket Steve Waugh played well to save his team some blushes. He was eventually out for 80, caught by me at deep square leg off Anil. The crowd was desperate for a final Steve Waugh hundred but it didn't work out that way. Straight after taking the catch, I ran over to Steve and congratulated him on a fantastic career and wished him all the best for his future endeavours as he received a standing ovation from the Sydney crowd.

Australia held on for a draw and the series finally ended 1–1. Personally, it had been a great Test match for me and I was satisfied at having kept my promise to Ajit not to get out in both innings. It had been extremely difficult to go against my natural instincts. But it was a series we really should have won. We were the better team for most of it and had played exceptional cricket in patches. Had the declaration on the